



Crucial Conversation Prep Worksheet

Scenario Example: An employee has been making inappropriate sexual jokes.



1. Lead with the Heart

Purpose: Begin with empathy and the genuine intent to help the employee understand the seriousness of the issue while protecting a respectful, safe workplace for everyone.

Example Reflection: “I want to handle this conversation in a way that preserves the individual’s dignity while making it clear that this behavior isn’t acceptable. My intent is to correct the behavior, not to shame the person.”

Prompts:

- What might be motivating this behavior — humor, attention, habit, or lack of awareness?
- How can I show care for the person while maintaining professionalism?
- How can I ensure the conversation stays calm, respectful, and focused on accountability?

Example Opening Line: “I wanted to have a quick but important conversation with you. I know you may not have meant harm, but some of your recent comments have made others uncomfortable, and I want to talk about that directly and respectfully.”



2. Define the Ideal Outcome

Purpose: Clearly visualize what “success” looks like after the conversation.

Example: “By the end of this discussion, I want the employee to understand why sexual jokes are inappropriate in the workplace, acknowledge the impact, and commit to changing the behavior moving forward.”



3. Define the Negative Outcome to Avoid

Purpose: Identify what could go wrong if emotions or defensiveness take over.

Example: “I want to avoid the employee feeling personally attacked or embarrassed in a way that prevents learning. I also want to avoid minimizing the issue, which could undermine the importance of maintaining a respectful environment.”



4. Gather the Facts

Purpose: Enter the conversation equipped with objective information. Stick to specific examples, dates, and any feedback or complaints received — avoid hearsay or assumptions.

Example Notes:

- Several teammates reported discomfort after hearing sexual jokes made during team huddles.
 - The comments were made on [specific date(s)] and included remarks about coworkers' appearance.
 - No formal complaint yet, but HR has been informed.
 - The employee has not had prior disciplinary issues but has a generally casual communication style.
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5. Gain Buy-In After Presenting the Facts

Purpose: Invite the employee to share their perspective after explaining the concern. This builds understanding and encourages ownership.

Example Approach: “Now that I’ve explained what was shared with me, I’d like to hear your thoughts. Can you help me understand your perspective?”

Sample Questions to Ask:

- How do you feel hearing this feedback?
- Do you understand why this type of comment is inappropriate in the workplace?
- Do you see how this could make others uncomfortable?
- What can you do differently moving forward to help maintain a respectful environment?

6. Conversation Plan (Outline)

Example Flow and Dialogue:

1. Open with empathy and purpose

“I wanted to talk about something that’s come to my attention. My goal is to have an open, respectful discussion and make sure we’re aligned on our workplace expectations.”

2. Acknowledge their feelings

“I understand you may not have intended harm or offense. I appreciate your willingness to hear this feedback.”

3. Present the facts calmly

“There have been a few instances where you made sexual jokes in team settings, which made others uncomfortable. Those types of comments are not appropriate in a professional environment.”

4. Gain buy-in after presenting the facts

“Now that I’ve shared what’s been observed, how do you feel about this feedback? Do you understand why this behavior needs to stop?”

5. Collaborate on the way forward

“Let’s agree that this kind of humor won’t be used moving forward. I’m here to support you in making that change, but I also need to be clear that continuing this behavior could lead to disciplinary action.”

6. Reaffirm trust and partnership

“I believe this can be a learning moment, not a defining one. I know you’re capable of creating a positive, respectful environment, and I want to help you succeed in doing that.”



7. Reflection (After the Meeting)

- Did I lead with empathy and respect while remaining firm?
- Did I clearly communicate expectations and potential consequences?
- Did I allow space for the employee to share their point of view?
- Did I document the discussion for HR follow-up if needed?
- What went well? What could I improve next time?
